

Ethics in communication

Ethical communication is a type of communication that is predicated upon certain business values, such as being truthful, concise, and responsible with one's words and the resulting actions. As a set of principles, ethical communication understands that one's thoughts must be conveyed and expressed effectively and concisely, and that the resulting actions or consequences will [potentially] be based solely on how the message was communicated. Thus, ethical communication defines a framework or set of acceptable communication principles that align with an enterprise's overarching code of conduct or code of ethics.

Ethics are strategic forces that influence (and constrain) communications. Ethics refers to the principles of right and wrong that guide you in making decisions that consider the impact of your actions on others, as well as yourself. It is system of moral principles which deals with the human conduct, with respect to the right and wrong of certain actions.

Ethics in general have been classified into three types:



Normative ethics: These refer to values or code of conduct. These are guidelines for social interaction in a society. Normative ethics include the study of what you should do or should not do. Examples of normative ethics are honesty is good, lying is wrong, stealing is bad, my mom is a woman of integrity.

Applied ethics: Business and professional ethics are studied under this category. Since applied ethics are concerned with the application of ethics to the problems related to a special field. These are known as business or professional ethics. Business ethics or workplace ethics in communication are integral part of the decision-making process in workplace related problems. Some examples of applied ethics are allocation of scarce resources, conflict of interest, whistle blowing, surrogate decision making, research on animals, confidentiality of tax information, etc.

Meta ethics: Meta refers to an in-depth study of the discipline. The concepts include dead. Under meta. Ethics seem to be abstract and hence considered impractical by many. Ethics draw largely from the concept of perfection, such as perfectly good., perfectly duty bound, etc. Meta ethics are sometimes considered as seeking answers to questions about normative ethics, such as which acts are right by being, what things are good, or how we ought to lead our life.

Organizations have to manage sensitive information every day, whether it's an employee's personal tax information, news about financial results, or information about upcoming layoffs. Leaders are asked to treat such information confidentially, as leaked information can lead to an ethical issue, either within the company (internally) or for their customers and investors (externally). Any communication should follow these three ethical standards:

- **Honesty:** Honesty should be a feature of every communication, whether it is directed downward to employees, upward to management, laterally to other peers and departments, or externally. Facts and figures should be correct to the best of a preparer's knowledge. Precautions should be

taken to protect any sensitive information contained within. Honesty should also prevail when communicating goals, expectations, decisions, feedback, or judgments to employees.

- **Refrain from doing harm:** Whether communicating on a corporate or an individual level, the communication should make every effort to cause no harm. For instance, tobacco companies are required to communicate that the practice of consuming their products may lead to physical conditions like emphysema or lung cancer. A company who is aware of a danger like that and doesn't communicate it would be breaking this rule of ethical communication.
- **Fairness to all stakeholders (internal and external):** When communicating internally or externally, the organization should attempt to be fair to its employees, customers, and community. If a manager were to exert inappropriate control over employees, stockholders, or customers, this would be a violation of this standard. Price fixing, bribery, and insider trading are examples of behaviors and communications that are exerting unfairness to stakeholder.

Principles of Ethical Communication

There are a myriad of core principles associated with ethical communication, starting with the core value of honesty that all other values are connected to. However, it can be said that there is a value underlying honesty (with regard to ethical communication) and that is emotional intelligence/empathy as the precursor of all soft skills, which allows all personnel to be understood, and to effectively communicate with others. Emotional intelligence, within the framework of ethical communication, allows one to understand the needs of others, and meet those needs in the most efficient manner as far as possible.

1. **Be Truthful and Honest:** Being honest means communicating what is known to be true to a listener, with no intent to deceive or present only parts of the truth. It also means being as objective as possible, that is, not tailoring the story based on what the speaker *wants* the listener to believe. Letting the listener take the data that is objectively presented and believe what they choose to believe is a core goal of ethical communication. Ethical communication should be based on accurate information and facts – in a word, *do not lie*.
2. **To build trust and credibility:** The success of any organization depends on the trust and credibility that it earns from its employees, customers, shareholders, etc. Credibility and trust are broad concepts and unless an organization practices honesty and fairness in communication dealings, these two concepts cannot become part of its workplace environment.
3. **Speak Non-Judgmentally:** Ethically and concisely communicating means speaking in a non-judgmental manner with every recipient, negating unnecessary conflict, which typically creates a breakdown in communication and causes misunderstandings. Unnecessary conflict is never good for any business, and such conflicts usually result from unethical communications, with judgmental, accusatory, and overly-critical comments often being the catalyst for such breakdowns in communication.
4. **To treat everyone with dignity:** When an organization treats its employees with respect and dignity, each individual feels a sense of loyalty towards it. In order to nurture and use individual skills and potentials, it is imperative that each business organization/ workplace motivates and encourages its employees for improved performance. The workplace should be free of discrimination. Offensive, abusive and harassing behavior should be discouraged.

5. **To facilitate open and honest communication:** It is the responsibility of every management that it should create a climate and culture of open and honest communication. This will lead to participative decision-making. Ethical concerns should be discussed freely without fear of the superiors.
6. **Strive To Understand:** While it is important to be proactive in listening, it is important for listeners to also strive to fully understand what is being said before responding. While asking for clarification or confirmation of a point is fine, many times questions that listeners pose have already been answered. Listeners should think about what has been said before constructing a reply. Reading “in between the lines” is also an important skill that allows for understanding what *is not* said, but was implicitly said or implied.
7. **Avoid A Negative Tone:** Ethically communicating assumes the speaker will avoid rudeness, be polite and professional, and have *tact*. The ethical communicator knows that it’s not only important what you say, but how you say it. *Tone* is one of the most critical facets of communication. A listener may miss the meaning altogether if the tone is wrong, which can lead to unnecessary confrontations that decrease business productivity. Controlling one’s tone goes along with self-control, a soft skill that allows one to know how they wish to reply to a terse business message (for instance) versus the most effective manner for replying. Essentially, keeping the tone positive or neutral is best, as the tone of a written message – or of one’s voice – is always picked up by the receiver, and can alter how the message is received and/or understood.
8. **Do Not Interrupt Others:** Allowing others to speak is important for the creation of a civil, effective working environment. Interrupting others results in misunderstandings and unnecessary conflicts and a breakdown in workplace communications, which only hinders corporate progress and creates problems. Interrupting others not only shows a lack of respect, but does not allow the listener to fully grasp what is being said, which often results in incorrect assumptions being made.
9. **Respect Privacy and Confidentiality:** Employees are entitled to use company’s resources such as time, material, equipment, information for company’s purpose only. Occasional permission is allowed as long as it does not affect job performance or disrupts the workplace environment. Most businesses or communication in workplace should include a clause in their code of ethics defining what is appropriate when it comes to honoring client and employee confidentiality and privacy. This can have a wide range of implications, including minimizing workplace gossip, and mitigating toxic conversations about the private lives of clients and/or personnel.
10. **To ensure safety:** Attaching a clear defined safety manual along with warning, will bring about a clean and honest image of the company.

Bias-free Communication

Bias-free language refers to non-discriminatory language. You may, for example, swap out the term “spokesman” (a male-centric term) for “spokesperson” in an organizational context. In many instances, individuals face the challenge of substituting discriminatory terms with suitable neutral alternative. It refers to words or phrases that are considered as not offensive or hurtful to others. Bias-free language is language that is sensitive to people's sex, race, age, physical condition and many other categories. Bias-free language does not discriminate and therefore includes all readers in a fair and friendly manner.

Bias typically involves a leaning or predisposition on an issue that may inhibit being neutral when communicating with others. When bias exists in attitudes, it is often reflected in the language and the way in which individuals interact with each other. Language can have a significant impact on the quality of our interactions. Many times, we do not intend to exclude or offend others by the words we choose. We

may simply lack information about, and sensitivity to, certain words or phrases. Being aware and mindful of our language, both written and oral, can help create a supportive and inclusive climate. This document provides suggestions for eliminating bias from our communication as one means of creating a more inclusive environment and modeling the attitudes about diversity which the University values. While some basic suggestions are offered below, the key to effective bias-free communication is treating all people with respect and consideration regardless of characteristics such as age, gender, gender identity, race, color, religion, national origin, height, weight, familial status, marital status, sexual orientation, disability, or political preference.

General guidelines for bias-free communication include:

- Pay special attention not to limit or imply limitations for anyone to participate in any activity, occupation or area of study, e.g. "his disability will preclude him from doing this job," "women shouldn't play certain sports."
- Speak of all members of the University community--students, faculty and staff--in relationship to the issues at hand and the abilities of those involved.
- Assign tasks on the basis of ability rather than gender, race, disability, or other irrelevant stereotypical characteristics, e.g. "we need a man to lift this computer."
- Diversity in leadership and presenters is important in demonstrating bias-free communication.
- Every reasonable effort should be made to assure that meeting places are barrier-free and can accommodate persons with disabilities.
- Every person at a meeting or gathering should be given opportunities to participate.
- "In-group" references and comments, while they may enhance the workplace for the in-group, may create an unwelcoming or hostile working or educational environment for non-members.
- Avoid stereotyping or patronizing racial or ethnic groups, LGBT persons, or persons with disabilities in news stories, anecdotes or hiring practices.

There are other, more characteristic-specific guidelines for bias-free communication that can increase awareness of, and confidence in, our use of inclusive language. These guidelines change from time-to-time, and individuals or groups most often affected by bias suggest such changes. While these guidelines are common recommendations, they may not be the preference of every individual. The overall goal is to be sensitive and try to communicate in a way that everyone can feel included.

Race and Ethnicity

Avoid qualifiers that imply that all members of specific ethnic groups or races are the same, e.g., suggesting that all persons of a certain ethnicity are good at athletics or math. If you specify race or ethnic origin, be certain it is relevant. Avoid language that has questionable racial or ethnic connotations, e.g., "you people," or "those foreigners."

Gender Identity and Sexual Orientation

Use gender-neutral words/phrases in your language, e.g. journalist, fire fighter, chairperson. Avoid the use of "man" or "woman" in job titles like manpower- human resources or labor, policeman- police officer, cameraman- camera operator or camera person and the like. Address both female and male perspectives with phrases like "employees and their spouses or partners." We should avoid describing men by profession and women by physical attributes. Use "gender" rather than "sex" to differentiate between men and women. In case of sexual orientation use of certain phrases like "the gay lifestyle" or "sexual preference" should be avoided and phrases like "partner or spouse" should be used. When discussing families, be inclusive of families that are headed by same gender partners or lesbian, bisexual, gay, or transgender single parents and recognize the presence of LBGT youth in families. When using the terms "diversity" or "multicultural," and reference is made to specific groups, include lesbian-bi-gay-transgender persons in such statements.

Class

Discrimination should be avoided based on social class like upper class, middle class, lower class. Social stratification should be addressed in a manner avoiding hurtful remarks to a person. For example: upper class – privileged class, lower class – less privileged class and so on. Making a bias free statement regardless of class and social status, allows a person to put forth the views and makes living more convenient.

Age

Mention age only when it is relevant. Permit people of all ages to speak for themselves rather than assuming you know what they want. Avoid making inappropriate assumptions about people based on their age, e.g. elderly people- senior citizens, old lady – woman in her 60's, 70's, 80's. Ending bias takes awareness, openness and practice. Many biased statements seem so natural and familiar that we are unaware of the discomfort they cause for others. Become conscious of your communication and what it may imply.

Ability Status

Avoiding offensive expression and using "person first" instead of their disabilities, e.g., "person with a disability," "student with a disability." Avoid using the term "disability" as an adjective, e.g. the disability community. Avoid using adjectives as nouns, e.g. "the deaf, the blind, the disabled" rather we should use "people who are deaf", "mentally ill person" – a person with mental illness. Plan for and provide alternate forms of communications at events and gathering. This might include having interpreters, providing written materials in print format or in Braille, or providing oral interpretation for all visual information.